

THE WARD-STONE

An unofficial Baldur's Gate 3 spec script

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11 July 2026

A personal portfolio writing sample

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An unofficial *Baldur's Gate 3* spec script. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Larian Studios or Wizards of the Coast. All writing is original; no in-game dialogue is reproduced.

Scene · Act 1 · a wayshrine in **Greenharrow**, a wilderness hamlet · the party led by **Shadowheart**, with **Lae'zel**, **Karlach**, and **Gale**. An old warded relic, an innocent keeper, and four companions who each want something different from it.

THE SHRINE

Narrator: *As you enter the annex, you smell strong scents of beeswax and tea in the air. As you look around, you notice, at its heart, on a low ancient pedestal of river-stone worn smooth, a ward-stone the size of a heart. Silver veins faintly aglow, set apart and tended like the holy artifact it is. You take the room before you take the shrine: the doors, the old woman's hands, the ways out. Then the hum reaches you, low beneath the silver, and your attention snags where you did not send it. The thing is familiar — not the shrine, the pull of it, a sensation you'd have sworn you'd never felt and cannot now set down. Have you been here before?*

The old halfling beams at you the way people do when they have been alone with their pride too long.

Prue: Visitors! Sit, sit — kettle's just sung. Come to see her, have you? *(patting the ward-stone, familiar as a cat)* Everyone does, sooner or later. Mind — plenty on the road of late, but they don't stop in like you have. Pilgrims, I tell myself. *(a small shrug)* Though pilgrims usually want their tea.

Shadowheart — *(choose one)*

1. "So. Who guards this artifact at night?"
2. "We're only passing through. What is it?"
3. **[Religion]** "That's consecrated work. Moon-blessed — and set to *hold* something, unless I'm mistaken."
4. *(Say nothing. Let her talk.)*

Option 2 CHOSEN: Shadowheart: "We're only passing through. What is it?"

Prue: The Greenharrow ward-stone, dearie, set by the Moonmaiden's chosen when I was a girl in plaits. She keeps the bad-hearted things off — the wolves, aye, but *worse* things too: the ones that come in the dark, and in the dreams. *(no less cheerful)* There's four hamlets and the whole refugee road under her hand now. Without her? *(a comfortable certainty)* Oh, a

great many would die, dearie. That's why she's never left her stand, not once, in my sixty years. My Aldous — Selûne keep him — used to say the whole valley slept inside her cupped hand.

Narrator: *Refugees on the road from two days past had spoken of Greenharrow the way drowning men speak of driftwood. And there is something beneath the silver hum of the thing. It is a weight that your eyes cannot perceive clearly but the hair on the back of your neck insists is there.*

Shadowheart: *(circling the pedestal, half to herself)* She talks to it like it can hear her. My— (a beat; the catch arrives late) ...Never mind. (dry) All that devotion, poured into a moon-trinket. Well, the Moonmaiden always did prefer the ones who wouldn't ask questions.

Gale: *(head tilting, Gale catches a scent)* That hum. Do you feel it? Old-weave — unlike any ordinary village warding, dense as the old empires' craft. *(he steps closer, his voice drops)* No — I can feel *past* the warding. There's something *bound* under there. This isn't just a ward-stone, it's a *lid*. *(he looks up at you (Shadowheart) with dread)* I couldn't possibly tell you precisely what it holds down. I *can* tell you that a warding this deliberate is only ever built over something you'd give a very great deal to keep asleep — I believe lifting it could have devastating consequences, and not ones that stop at Greenharrow's fences.

Narrator: *Something in the floor comes alive, a pressure through the soles of your boots, there and gone before you can be sure of it. Whatever Gale has surmised is down there, some older part of you has already touched its edge: something vast and far down, older than the stone set over it. Not evil — wounded, and awake enough to know it wants out.*

Prue: *(delighted that Gale is impressed, oblivious)* Ooh, "old-weave"! Aldous never had a word so grand for her. Just "our girl." *(warming up)* And she does more than keep raiders off, mind. No whispers in the night, no mind-mists. Turns aside what creeps inside one's head. *(moves to set up her tea set)*

Lae'zel: *(pause)* It bars intrusion of the *mind*. *(covetous)* This is no hearth-charm, no peasants' comfort. It could be a shield against the ghaik, left to rot on a pedestal. We should requisition it.

Karlach: Whoa — no. Nope. *Absolutely* not, soldier. You heard the wizard — there's something *nasty* down under there, and that stone's the cork holding it in. You don't pull a cork when you can't see the bottom of the bottle.

Lae'zel: *(edged)* "A bottle." You reduce a weapon of war to tavern-drivel. Cockroaches, too, are content with the crumbs beneath the table.

Karlach: *(cheerful, not budging)* And what? You'd cook a whole village of grannies for a shiny paperweight, so maybe we're both a bit predictable today, eh, Lae? *(to the pedestal, gently)*

No offence, gorgeous.

Shadowheart: *(stepping into the middle, dry as flint)* So. Do we always haggle over stealing *this* loudly, or is today special? *(a hand up at each of them)* Lae'zel — set the word "requisition" down before you hurt someone with it. Karlach — stop defending the artifact. It's just a *rock*. *(to Gale, pragmatic)* Gale — you said this is old-weave. In plain terms: what is a thing like that actually *worth*? In the right hands and the wrong hands?

Gale: *(hands folding)* ...A great deal. I'll not insult anyone here by pretending otherwise — a knot of bound old-weave that size could *settle* a considerable share of my own more pressing difficulties, and I am the last man here entitled to pretend I hadn't noticed.

Lae'zel: *(seizing it, flat and immediate)* Then we are agreed. Even the wizard would profit — take it, and end this.

Gale: *(a short, pained breath)* We are agreed on *nothing*, and you have heard the exact opposite of what I said. *(steadier now with growing certainty)* A thing worth stealing is, nine times in ten, not worth the trouble it could bring down on our heads, much less this whole region. To weigh one's benefit against a whole region's ruin is not, I'm afraid, a close accounting. *(Gale's certainty thins; deflecting lighter tone)* Besides, I have every confidence the good people I travel with would rather a less *incendiary* remedy for my own predicament well in hand, right? *(flashes a bright smile)*

Narrator: *No one answers him quickly enough.*

Gale: *(echoing)* Right?

Prue: *(mishearing the tone entirely, thrilled)* Oh, you've all taken such a shine to her! Here — let me fetch her down, you can have a proper hold, feel how warm she could—

(She reaches for the pedestal.)

Karlach: *(a gentle lunge, both hands out)* No — no no no, she's — she's grand right where she is, Prue! Perfect. Don't trouble yourself. Wouldn't want anyone to... *drop* her. *(a look that sweeps the whole party)* Would we?

Narrator: *The artifact stands in front of you on the pedestal, within arm's reach. Whatever it keeps down has waited sixty years. It can wait a moment more. But could this be a test from Lady Shar? It is not unprecedented to show one's devotion at the expense of the innocent, especially ones who kneel to Selûne. Shar has never rewarded a gentle hand. A dark thought tugs on the corner of your mind. The opportunity seems too perfect.*

[Perception] VS 15 — success

Lae'zel: *(mid-breath — and then still; her head turns, and her blade is already in hand)* Silence. *(low, and certain)* Someone stands at that door, and wishes very much that we did not know it.

Narrator: *You pause to listen. Beneath all the noise: a boot-scuff on the threshold stone can be heard outside the front door of the annex — someone very close, and very quiet, lies in wait outside. For one more breath, it is yours to spend. The fate of Greenharrow could very well be in your hands. And Lady Shar is watching.*

Shadowheart — (choose one)

1. **[Persuasion] VS 12** — "Enough. We're guests, not grave-robbers, and I won't have us remembered as the second. Hands where I can see them. We walk."
2. **[Persuasion] VS 12** — *Talk everyone down* **[Deception] VS 13** — **[Take the artifact.]**
3. **[Turn to the door — call out whoever's there.]** *The presence, made, breaks and runs — the party can give chase and take the confrontation on their own terms. The one chance to catch the thieves red-handed.*
4. *(Say nothing. Let the others decide.)*

Had no one heard the door — had that Perception check failed — you (Shadowheart) would never be handed the choice to turn to the door at all. → see Branch D.

BRANCH A:

[Persuasion] VS 12 — success

Shadowheart: Enough, *(the room folds to her)* We're guests, not grave-robbers — and I won't have us remembered as the second. *(a glance that lands on each of them)* Hands where I can see them. We walk.

Karlach: *(breathes a sigh of relief, grinning)* That's — yeah. *That. (to Shadowheart, meaning it)* Knew there was a reason we let you do the talking. *(to the pedestal, softer)* Sorry, gorgeous. You're staying put. Best offer you'll get all week.

Lae'zel: *(a beat)* ...Tsk. The zaith'isk purifies; Vlaakith provides. This is scenery. *(she turns from the pedestal)* **[Karlach +1, Lae'zel +1]**

Gale: *(something in him eases)* I'll admit I wasn't certain which way this would go. I find myself more relieved that we all appealed to our better natures. *(lighter and pointed)* Because a company that leaves a village defenseless to gods-knows-what just to suit their own interests... is precisely the company a man in my particular predicament would very much not

like to be in. *(a small nod to the moment)* Shall we? Before the good woman offers us the pedestal as well.

Prue: *(delighted, understanding none of it)* Off already? Not without your tea and a bit of seedcake for the road! *(pressing warm parcels into your hands)* Take the moon's road, dearie, and mind the wolves past the mill. Do tell all folk — Greenharrow keeps well!

Narrator: *The stone hums on behind you, and though you will never feel it, a mile of quiet farmland lets out a breath and settles back to sleep. You wanted it. You could have pleased Shar tonight. And yet... you didn't. You walked out instead with your hands full of seedcake. The wanting comes too, unspent. But tonight, for once, it walks a step behind. And you hope — without much hope — that Shar won't hold one night of mercy against you.*

Aftermath. Nothing is taken; the wound stays asleep; Greenharrow lives another day. The only thread left hanging is the pair who never got their opening, a patient, professional interest that watched the shrine all evening and melted into the dusk when the party stayed alert. They do not forget an uncollected score.

(Later that night, at camp) **Karlach:** *(turning the little moon-charm Prue pressed on her)* Funny. We walked out with *less* than we could've, and I feel heavier in the good way. *(quieter)* ... Whoever was at that door, though. Bolted and ran the second we clocked 'em. That's not some chancer — that's someone who wanted that fancy stone and knew exactly what it was. Keep your blade where you can reach it, yeah?

BRANCH B:

[Persuasion] VS 12 — success

Narrator: *You argued everyone in the party down. There is a cold, clean pleasure in it: being the one steady hand. You let yourself have that much. And now the room is yours, and the pedestal lies open to you, and no one is watching.*

[Deception] VS 13 — success **Shadowheart:** *(evenly, without heat)* Prue. The kettle — I think it's caught. *(the old woman turns; Shadowheart plucks the ward-stone off the pedestal and stuffs it into her pack)*

Narrator: *The hum stops. The annex goes very quiet, and into that quiet, far down and far off, something vast turns over. You feel it wake before you hear it: a shift in the floor, a cold that finds the marrow.*

Karlach: *(smile falling)* ...Shadowheart. Shadowheart, look at me. Put it back. Put it back right now, and we pretend — *(her voice cracks toward something younger)* — I've heard what

happens to a place like Greenharrow when something this valuable leaves. Don't do this. Not you.

Shadowheart: *(she meets Karlach's eyes and smiles — practiced)* It's a *hamlet*, Karlach. Not a city. That's rather the whole point of the arithmetic, if you'd let me finish doing it. *(a light turn of the wrist)* The Moonmaiden's hoarded her treasures for sixty years — she can be generous the once. And I've somewhere a great deal more important to be than a widow's larder... or exploded by Gale. *(Shadowheart looks away from Karlach)* Oh, don't. You'll spoil the one genuinely useful thing about me. *(already turning, brisk)*

Lae'zel: *(cold approval)* So. The leader understands requisition after all. *(a single nod)* The wolf does not beg the lamb's pardon for its teeth. You are harder than you play at, Shadowheart. I approve.

Gale: *(he opens his mouth and closes it again)* I— *(a breath; held very level)* I am going to say nothing. I want that *noted*. That I said nothing, and what it cost me to say it. ... We should be gone before she turns round.

Prue: *(turning back, the kettle innocent in her hand)* Caught? No, dearie, she's singing fine as — *(her eyes go to the empty pedestal; confused)* Oh. Oh, where's she — where's my girl? Where's she gone? She was just— *(she looks at each of your faces, still trusting)*

Narrator: *No one answers her. You have what you came for, and a piece of yourself is already rehearsing the reasons. The ward-stone lies in your pack next to the astral prism. The wound is awake. You turn to leave. You tell yourself Shar would be proud. Whether or not she's proud is a question you set down unasked. [Karlach -10 · Gale -5 · Lae'zel +1]*

Aftermath. It does not take long. Within nights a child three doors down wakes screaming at a grey man in the window and will not wake again. The mill-keeper walks into the river, certain it is the road home. Whatever the stone kept out for sixty years finds the gap where its hum used to be. In your pack the silver has already gone cold — a Selûnite relic, dead in a Sharran's hands.

(camp, later) **Karlach:** Greenharrow's gone cold. You might not be — not yet. Fix that. *(flat, no heat)* While it's still fixable.

BRANCH C:

[Persuasion] VS 12 — failure

Shadowheart: Enough. We're guests, not grave-robbers, and I won't have us — *Lae'zel*. Lae'zel, do **not** —

Lae'zel: *(already moving)* Deliberation is a luxury of the unthreatened. *(her fist closes around the ward-stone before she finishes)*

Narrator: *The hum stops mid-note, and for one breath the floor goes wrong under every boot in the room, a lurch with no source, there and gone.*

Karlach: *(lunging, too late, hands grabbing air)* LAE'ZEL — put it — gods, put it *back*, put it back put it back —

Gale: *(flailing)* That — that is the precise course of action I expended considerable breath advising against, and I should like it *formally noted* that —

Lae'zel: *(cold, closing her hand tight around the ward-stone)* It is done. Recriminate on the march.

Prue: *(clapping, delighted and misreading the situation)* Oh, careful, dears — she's slippery when she's excited! *(beaming)* But you've got her! There now — isn't she a wonder up close?

Shadowheart: *(rounding on Lae'zel)* Put. It. Down. You couldn't sit still for the length of *one conversation* — you've just cracked a sixty-year ward over a *hunch*.

Lae'zel: *(edged)* "A hunch." The moon-priestess mourns turnip-farmers she would not remember past the next mile-marker. I have lifted a shield against the thing that eats minds. When the ghaik come whispering into your sleep, *istik*, you will wish you had thanked me.

Narrator: *The word "moon-priestess" lands somewhere it has no business landing. For half a second something behind your eyes goes very still. You do not correct it. Correcting it would cost more than letting it stand.*

Shadowheart: *(flint — level, controlled, colder)* I don't want your shield, Lae'zel. I wanted us to walk out of here with clean hands — and not for the *virtue* of it. A party that robs shrines is a party the next door doesn't open for, and we have a long road still to walk. *(a beat)* You couldn't even give me that.

Karlach: *(stepping between them)* STOP. All of you. *Stop.* *(pointing, low and furious)* There is a woman standing right there who does not yet know her entire life just walked out the door. So maybe we do the screaming *later*. Yeah?

Prue: *(the joy finally faltering)* ...Dears? Is — is everything quite right?

Shadowheart: *(she turns — precise, unhurried — to leave. Over her shoulder, flat and final)* We're done here. Do what you like with it. You always will anyway.

Narrator: *Everyone follows you out — Lae'zel with her prize, Gale with his silence, Karlach last of all, looking back once at the old woman she cannot help. You have the stone you told them*

not to take. What you don't have, what you won't get back by asking for it, is any certainty that they'll hold the next time you say hold. [Karlach –10 · Gale –5]

Aftermath. The ward-stone is gone, and Greenharrow gets what a broken ward gets. The dreams. The grey men at the windows. The rot on the road. The ward-stone's silver goes cold and dead; Lae'zel calls it superstition, which only makes it colder. And the four of you do not walk out as four anymore. Karlach won't look at Lae'zel. She won't quite look at you either.

BRANCH D:

[Perception] VS 15 — failure.

A sound is heard at the front door. No one hears it. Lae'zel's head never turns; the boot-scuff at the threshold goes unmarked beneath four raised voices; no one calls the door. And so you (Shadowheart) are never handed the choice to turn to the door because you are now simply too distracted.

[Persuasion] VS 12 — failure

Shadowheart: For the *last* time, we are **not** —

Lae'zel: You have declared "the last time" on four occasions, moon-priestess. Your discipline is theatre.

Karlach: (*wading in, arms wide, herding them like geese*) Okay — OKAY — everybody, deep breath. Deep breath, everyone. Prue's got tea, nobody's touching the rock, we are simply — having a chat. A loud chat. About a rock. In a nice lady's house.

Gale: (*pitching over the din, to no one*) If I might reintroduce a *note of arcane precision* to the proceedings! The salient point that everyone appears to be —

Shadowheart: (*over him*) — Lae'zel, if you say "requisition" one more time —

Lae'zel: (*over her*) Requi—

Prue: (*to a knock on the front door, delighted*) Oh — more visitors! Come in, come in, dears, it's a *busy* day for the old girl!

[Perception] VS 15 — failure.

Narrator: *Two travellers step in. One raises a hand as if in greeting; a small charm slips from the gesture and takes hold of Prue before it fully forms. Her face warms — old friends. You do not see the second one cross the room. You could not: the air around them lies flat and eats every footfall. And you are not looking. You are too certain the only concern is right in front of*

you. And so a shadowed hand you never marked lifts the ward-stone from the pedestal. The hum stops. Two hooded backs are already in the doorway, and the lane beyond is empty.

Karlach: *(trailing off mid-gesture)* ...Wait. Hang on. Why's it — why's it gone quiet?

Shadowheart: *(head turning, slow, dread creeping in)* ...The pedestal.

Lae'zel: *(already at the front door, blade half-drawn)* Gone. Two of them — south, and the very air closes behind them. *(a snarl of grudging assessment)* Trained. Disciplined. Human work, and better than your kind has any right to be. I did not hear them breathe.

Gale: *(crouching quick beside Prue, fingers raised to her temple)* ...Oh. Oh, no. There's a Charm on her — a hasty one. They reached into this poor woman's *head* and made sure she didn't draw any attention to them. *(rising, appalled)* Whoever they were, they were not amateurs. And they left in a hurry.

[Perception / Investigation] VS 13 — success Narrator: *There, by the door-jamb, dropped in the rogue's hurry: a courier's cargo-tag stamped with a single coiled serpent. It must've fallen when the stone went into the thief's cloak.*

Karlach: *(turning it over)* ...Huh. I've seen a mark like that. Baldur's Gate — the arms crowd, the ones who smile while they count your teeth. *(a frown)* Bad news with a smile. Can't put a name to it, though. Been too long, and too far.

[History] VS 10 — success Gale: The coiled serpent. The Black Network. *Zhentarim*. Smugglers, couriers, killers-for-coin, and no loyalty that outlasts the payment. *(a beat, cold)* Which raises the far worse question of who is *paying* them to lift a Selûnite ward-stone off a pedestal in the middle of nowhere. But that's a thread for a darker campfire than this one.

Prue: *(still charmed, turning from the door)* ...Did your nice friends have to rush off, then? *(a small, contented laugh)* Didn't even stop for a seedcake.

Narrator: *The ward-stone goes south in a stranger's pack, toward whatever coin commissioned it, and the wound it kept shut wakes a little more with every mile. Your chance to please Shar came and went while you argued. And Shar notices when a servant loses focus. Whether the stone's loss is a defeat or a mercy in her eyes, you don't let yourself ask.*

Aftermath. Greenharrow dies the same death by a worse hand: the dreams, the grey men, the rot on the road. And this time you did not even *choose* it. The Black Network does what it always does: the ward-stone goes up the smuggling line, and the buyer at the top of that line has been paying Zhentarim couriers to run stranger cargo than a moon-relic. What the Absolute cult wants with such a relic that *turns aside what creeps into sleeping heads* is not a trophy. It is an obstacle to be removed, or a lock to be studied. You will see the ward-stone again. Will you fail the next time?

*Companion voices per Act-1 characterization (Shadowheart / Lae'zel / Karlach / Gale). Original
pastiche; unaffiliated with Larian Studios and Wizards of the Coast.*